attempting to destroy that arsenal through a counterforce strike. Opponents in a counterforce environment might seek to obtain additional warheads, thereby setting off a spiral of weapons acquisitions.[11]

Unlike counterforce weapons, missile defense capabilities would destroy the enemy's nuclear forces after launch, rather than on the ground. This technical difference aside, however, BMD would achieve much the same strategic result as counterforce weapons, preventing a state from effectively using its nuclear forces to retaliate against its adversary. As with counterforce weapons, this could create first-strike incentives. If a state feared that its adversary was contemplating an attack against its nuclear forces or command and control, and its adversary also possessed a missile defense capability, the state could be sorely tempted to launch its forces first. This would get the state's forces off the ground before they were hit by the expected attack and would maximize the number of weapons the adversary's BMD would have to intercept simultaneously, thereby increasing the likelihood that some of the weapons would get through the system and reach enemy soil. If the state did not strike first, and a significant percentage of its nuclear forces were destroyed or incapacitated in the enemy's initial attack, the enemy's BMD might be able to absorb the state's remaining forces. In this situation, the state would be unable to use its nuclear forces to retaliate against an attack and would thus be rendered essentially defenseless.[12]

In addition to possible first-strike temptations, a state facing a BMD-equipped adversary might have strong incentives to arms race. The more weapons the state can launch at the enemy, the greater the likelihood that it could exceed the missile defense system's capabilities, which would ensure that at least some of its weapons reach enemy territory. Thus the state could seek to expand the size of its nuclear arsenal.[13]

These strategic effects could adversely impact India's security relationships with its two principal adversaries, Pakistan and China. Pakistan possesses a relatively small nuclear arsenal, probably numbering about sixty warheads.[14] Even a modest Indian missile defense capability could erode Pakistan's ability to retaliate after an